saying we stopped a war with Iran, saving countless lives, but I am saying we set out in that direction and achieved a smaller goal. There has not been a war with Iran, and that is partly because covert operations in that region have been interrupted and dangerous incursions along those borders have been prevented; and we were instrumental in that. We don't want the credit; we merely want the outcome. But it's appropriate to note that no news organisation in the world, no TV station baying for our blood, would ever focus on this aspect of what we do every day.

The Iraq video set the tone for many, especially among the US establishment, who wished to see us a certain way. It was obvious to us, and perhaps to a whole generation of people, that they were railing against the technology as much as against WikiLeaks. We couldn't help them with that: we are not a public relations firm – and don't do well in that area – but our work has been various and consistent and without partisan interests or state sponsorship, and that is how it will always be. We published the video and woke up infamous, though we take no pleasure in infamy. Rather, we find it odd to exist in a world where attempts to advance justice and the freedom of the press can cause one to be regarded as an enemy. Still, we left Washington with a sense of having done our work. No more than that. Neither triumphalism nor sense of defeat, for both were possible, given first the impact of the video and the scorn it had brought down on us.

We were galvanised, though. It was a pleasure to get to Berkeley in California, where we may no longer see students pushing flowers down military gun barrels but there is always a sense of change, or of progress, moving over the Bay. I was reminded of childhood days in the warm atmosphere of gentle protest there and felt we had a good audience – not a captive one but a free one – when Birgitta and Gavin MacFadyen of the Centre for Investigative Journalism joined me in speaking about developments in the freedom of the press. We went from there, soon after, to the Oslo Peace Forum, where I felt an uplifting sense of clarity after the video. 'Our goal is to have a just civilisation,' I said, 'and the message is transparency.' Given the flak we were taking, and were about to take, I knew it was important to underscore our commitment as existing outside of ideology. 'We are neither left nor right,' I said, and I meant it. It would cause a certain amount of wailing on either side, but we are not consistent with the old categories, and have never felt pressed to curry favour with a party. History teaches us of cover-ups and brutalities on both sides, no less